SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

AWARENESS AND KNOWLEDGE OF BASIC CONSUMER RIGHTS: AN ASSESSMENT STUDY

A Thesis Presented To
The Faculty of
College of Business Management

In Partial Requirements for the Degree
Bachelor of Science in Business Administration Major in Financial Management

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ABSTRACT

TITLE: AWARENESS AND KNOWLEDGE OF BASIC CONSUMER RIGHTS: AN ASSESSMENT STUDY

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1. **OBJECTIVES:**

This study aims to assess the awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights as mandated under Republic Act 7394 and reinforced by DTI Policy Advisory No. 22-01.

`II. METHODOLOGY:

This study will utilize a structured survey questionnaire as its main data-gathering instrument. This tool was modified from the study of Chona Pajarillo-Agustin in her research study entitled *"Consumer Awareness Assessment Survey in the Province of Cagayan"* and further aligned with the Department of Trade and Industry's (DTI) issued guidance on the eight (8) basic consumer rights as outlined by eLegal Philippines (2022).

III. FINDINGS:

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS:

KEYWORDS: Consumer Awareness, 8 Basic Consumer Rights, Consumer Rights, RA 7394, Consumers

DEDICATION

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Consumer protection has become a global priority as markets continue to expand across physical and digital platforms. Internationally, greater emphasis has been placed on strengthening consumer protection systems to ensure fair trade practices, product safety, and accessible redress mechanisms. The United Nations Guidelines for Consumer Protection, (2022) reaffirm that consumers must have access to accurate information, safe products, effective complaint channels, and education that empowers them to make informed choices. Likewise, the ASEAN Consumer Protection Framework, (2021) highlights the need for consistent consumer safeguards across Southeast Asia, emphasizing digital marketplace protection, cross-border trade fairness, and consumer redress mechanisms. These studies, carried out by (Koos, 2021) and (Buana Rumiartha and Indradewi, 2020), illustrate that consumer protection laws should be based on a socially responsible market economy in which fairness is seen as an end in itself, alongside efficiency. Again, (Widiarty and Fahim, 2024) also drew on institutional mechanisms that needed strengthening by governments to ensure effectiveness in enforcement within an increasingly globalized trade environment. Comparative analysis across nations have shown that different enforcements create inconsistent levels of confidence among consumers. (Galasintu & Loveera, 2021; Dewi et al., 2024) present this argument. As digital markets grow in complexity, so also do the challenges multiply in consumer protection, which require policy reforms that reinforce accountability and consumer redress systems. (Hlaing, 2024; Agbo-Ejeh, 2023). (Ahmed, 2020) and (Mia and Malliick, 2021) established that enforcement mechanisms were weak in securing compliance from producers and ensuring trust in legal redress. Comparative work by (Gum, 2025) in South Sudan and (Tshiki, 2025) in South Africa indicated that conditions of living, education, and

government efficiency play an important role in determining the extent of protection frameworks utilized by citizens.

In the Southeast Asian context, several scholars have discussed consumer protection's evolution and limitations: law consistency in designing socially responsible consumer legislation was discussed by (Koos, 2021), while (Arellano-Asas, 2024) reviewed the challenges in implementing the Philippine Consumer Act. (Galasintu and Loveera, 2021) compared the legal frameworks of ASEAN nations and identified gaps in both harmonization and enforcement capacity. Nationally, several studies have explored how people's understanding of how consumer laws and the way those laws are enforced. (Baquiran et al., 2024) investigated students' awareness of RA 7394, finding significant knowledge gaps among even educated demographics. (Alonzo and Caurel, 2023) reported that consumers in Northern Philippines often rely on informal dispute resolution, indicative of low engagement with formal legal mechanisms. Similarly, (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023) found that while awareness campaigns in Cagayan Province helped people better understand their consumer rights, this didn't lead to a noticeable rise in formal complaints being filed. In the Philippine national context, consumer welfare is protected primarily through Republic Act 7394, otherwise known as Consumer Act of the Philippines. This law lays out the standards for product quality, fair trade, business practices, redress, and education.

To strengthen public understanding, the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) issued Policy Advisory No. 22-01 in May 2022, clarifying the eight (8) Basic Consumer Rights; Rights to Basic Needs, Rights to Safety, Rights to Information, Rights to Choose, Rights to Representation, Rights to Redress, Rights to Consumer Education, and Rights to a Healthy Environment. (Disini & Disini Law Office, 2022) The Eight Basic Consumer Rights in the Philippines are fundamental protections guaranteed by the constitution and various laws to ensure the welfare of consumers.

The Right to Basic Needs, ensures access to essential goods and services such as food, clothing, shelter, health care, education, utilities, water, and sanitation, safeguarded by the 1987 Constitution and laws like the Price Act (RA 7581) and the Local Government Code (RA 7160). The Right to Safety, protects consumers from hazardous products and services, upheld by the Consumer Act (RA 7394), the Food Safety Act (RA 10611), and provisions under the Local Government Code. The Right to Information, guarantees consumers access to truthful facts for informed choices, protecting them against deceptive advertising and labeling through RA 7394 and the No Shortchanging Act (RA 10909). The Right to Choose, allows consumers to select from a range of quality products and services at competitive prices, supported by the Philippine Competition Act (RA 10667). The Right to Representation, ensures consumer interests are considered in government policy-making and product development, as provided under RA 7394 and RA 7581. The Right to Redress, grants consumers fair settlement of claims and compensation for defective or misrepresented goods and services, protected by RA 7394 and RA 8293. The Right to Consumer Education, empowers individuals with knowledge and skills to make informed decisions, reinforced by RA 7394, RA 3720, and RA 9211, which mandate warnings, information drives, and school curricula on consumer hazards. Finally, the Right to a Healthy Environment, guarantees a safe and sustainable environment for present and future generations, enshrined in the 1987 Constitution, RA 7394, and RA 9003. (Disini & Disini Law Office, 2022) these rights, while supported by specific laws, are not exclusive, as other statutes and regulations may also serve as sources of consumer protection.

As much as possible, these eight rights should be invoked in all matters concerning consumer protection, including settlements, decisions, and resolutions in mediation or adjudication of consumer complaints. (Melad et al., 2023) noticed that, although consumers

generally show satisfaction with the available protection mechanisms, most of them remain unfamiliar with RA 7394's legal remedies. These findings support the results of earlier studies by (Devi and Kalita, 2020) and (Nathiya and Kasthuri, 2021), which showed that people's awareness of their consumer rights often depends on their level of education, income, and where they live. These studies collectively demonstrate that despite strong national laws in the Philippines, local enforcement and awareness are unstable. Very few scholarly works in the Caraga Region, particularly in Agusan del Norte, have assessed how RA 7394 is implemented and the extent to which consumers actively exercise their rights. While the Department of Trade and Industry Caraga and ConsumerNet initiatives report ongoing information drives, no academic study has measured their impacts at the provincial level. Understanding these elements will not only provide a measure of the current effectiveness of RA 7394 but will also serve as a guide to policy recommendations toward strengthening consumer confidence and enforcement strategies in the region.

The purpose of the study is to evaluate how well consumers understand and exercise their legally protected rights. It aims to determine the level of awareness among individuals regarding the eight basic consumer rights, such as the right to basic needs, safety, information, choice, representation, redress, consumer education, and a healthy environment, and to assess how effectively government policies, laws, and consumer education programs have reached the public. The study seeks to uncover whether consumers can assert these rights when faced with unfair trade practices, unsafe products, or misleading information. The gap addressed by this study lies in the limited empirical evidence available in the Philippines that measures consumer awareness and knowledge across different demographics. While laws and regulations on consumer protection are well established, few studies focus on whether consumers themselves are empowered to use these rights. Existing studies tends to emphasize legal frameworks and

enforcement mechanisms rather than the actual level of consumer understanding. By filling this gap, the study provides evidence-based insights into the strengths and weaknesses of consumer awareness, highlighting areas where education, advocacy, and enforcement must be improved to ensure that consumer rights are not only legally guaranteed but also practically exercised.

The significance of this study extends to multiple stakeholders, such as consumers, the results will inform them of the extent of their current knowledge and may encourage them to be more proactive in claiming their rights. For the Department of Trade and Industry (DTI) and Local Government Units (LGUs), the study can serve as a basis for designing more focused consumer awareness and advocacy programs in Agusan del Norte. Business establishments may also gain insights into consumer awareness levels, which can encourage better compliance with RA 7394 and foster more ethical trade practices. Meanwhile, the College of Business and Management (CBM) department can utilize the recent data generated by the study for curricular enhancement, the development of teaching modules, and the integration of consumer protection concepts into business-related courses. In addition, the CBM department can use the study as a valuable reference for students and faculty in learning consumer laws and understanding consumer rights within a practical, localized context, thereby strengthening both academic instruction and research initiatives in the field of business and management.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

This chapter presents a comprehensive review of studies related to consumer rights awareness, demographic influences, and access to consumer information. The review is organized to align with the study's conceptual framework, beginning with literature on demographic profile variables, followed by access to consumer information, and finally the Eight Basic Consumer Rights as the dependent variables. By synthesizing local, national, and international research, this chapter

highlights the theoretical and empirical foundations of consumer awareness and provides justification for the variables examined in this study.

Consumer protection has become increasingly important due to the rapid expansion of markets, digital platforms, and the growing complexity of product and service offerings. International policies such as the United Nations Guidelines for Consumer Protection and national frameworks like the Philippine Republic Act No. 7394 underscore the necessity of safeguarding consumer welfare. However, despite strong legal foundations, disparities in awareness and access persist, particularly in rural and developing areas. This chapter therefore discusses the existing literature to establish how demographic factors, information sources, and consumers' rights collectively influence consumer protection outcomes.

Exposure to Mass Media

Mass media—including television, radio, newspapers, and social media—plays a significant role in shaping consumer awareness. The (ITU, 2024) highlights mass media as a principal channel for disseminating consumer protection information in developing regions. (OECD, 2023) similarly finds that consumers exposed to mass media exhibit higher awareness of risks, rights, and available redress mechanisms. Philippine studies by (Baquiran et al., 2024) demonstrate that students who regularly engage with media-based advisories show greater knowledge of the Eight Consumer Rights. Local provincial surveys in Cagayan and Quirino also indicate that communities reached by DTI announcements have higher levels of awareness (Melad et al., 2023; Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023). Exposure to mass media plays a crucial role in shaping consumers' awareness of their rights, particularly in rapidly changing markets where product risks and fraudulent practices are common. Thus, exposure to mass media is a strong predictor of consumer rights literacy.

International organizations such as the (ITU, 2024) emphasize that mass media—including television, radio, and digital platforms—serve as critical channels for disseminating consumer protection information, especially in developing economies where institutional outreach may be limited. (OECD, 2023) likewise found that consumers who frequently engage with mass media tend to have higher awareness of marketplace risks, deceptive advertising, and available redress mechanisms. Philippine studies echo this pattern; (Baquiran et al., 2024) reported that students exposed to consumer-related programs and announcements through social media and television demonstrated significantly higher awareness of the Eight Basic Consumer Rights under RA 7394. Moreover, provincial surveys such as those conducted in Quirino and Cagayan show that communities receiving television and radio advisories from DTI had more consistent knowledge of the Right to Safety and Right to Information than those in remote barangays with limited media access (Melad et al., 2023; Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023). Taken together, these findings establish mass media as a strong predictor of consumer rights awareness because it provides wide-reaching, timely, and accessible information for all consumer groups.

Exposure to Printed Materials

Exposure to printed materials—such as brochures, posters, flyers, and product labels—is equally important in enhancing awareness of consumer rights. Printed information remains essential for consumers in rural and low-connectivity areas who may not have regular access to digital platforms or mass media. Printed materials such as brochures, posters, manuals, and labels remain vital sources of information for consumers, especially in communities with limited digital access. (Dewi et al., 2024) emphasize that printed materials are effective in Asian settings, where community dissemination often occurs through physical distribution. In the Philippines, (Javier et al., 2024) link printed material exposure—particularly label reading—to higher levels of safety

awareness. Provincial studies note that printed DTI posters and announcements visibly improve consumer knowledge, especially in rural areas (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023).

Printed materials therefore play a critical role in bridging information gaps. Philippine evidence also highlights the value of printed sources. (Javier et al., 2024) found that Filipinos who frequently read product labels and printed advisories demonstrated stronger understanding of safety information and product standards, directly supporting the Right to Safety and Right to Information. Surveys in Quirino and Cagayan provinces further showed that printed DTI posters placed in stores and public areas increased consumers' familiarity with rights such as redress and representation, even among those with limited media exposure (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023). Because printed materials are tangible, simple, and easily accessible, they remain one of the most reliable tools for promoting consumer literacy, particularly for seniors, PWDs, and rural communities who depend on non-digital communication.

Exposure to Institutional and Community Sources

Institutional and community-based sources—such as DTI seminars, barangay sessions, and school campaigns—greatly enhance consumer rights awareness. The (OECD, 2023) emphasizes that institutional information is more credible and impactful compared to commercial or unregulated sources. In the Philippines, (Baquiran et al., 2024) found that institutional learning boosts awareness of RA 7394. Community-based surveys in Cagayan and Quirino also confirmed that participation in barangay orientations or LGU-led programs improves understanding of the Right to Redress and Representation (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023). Institutional exposure thus strengthens consumer confidence and knowledge.

Institutional and community-based information sources—such as DTI seminars, barangay orientations, school campaigns, and organizational activities—play a major role in building

consumer literacy. (OECD, 2023) asserts that institutional information is often more trusted than commercial or media-based sources because it is perceived as unbiased and authoritative. (ITU, 2024) similarly stresses that governments and consumer organizations must remain key actors in educating citizens about marketplace rights and risks. In the Philippines, studies show strong support for this variable. (Baquiran et al., 2024) found that students who received consumer education directly from schools or government-led workshops had substantially higher awareness of their rights under RA 7394. Community-based surveys conducted in Cagayan and Quirino provinces revealed that barangay-led and LGU-supported campaigns helped increase citizens' awareness of the Right to Redress, Right to Representation, and Right to Consumer Education (Melad et al., 2023; Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023). Because institutional channels provide structured, targeted, and accurate information, they serve as vital mechanisms for bridging awareness gaps, especially in remote areas where mass media penetration is low.

Right to Basic Needs

The Right to Basic Needs ensures consumers' access to essential goods and services at reasonable prices. According to the (United Nations, 2022), equitable access to essential goods forms the foundation of consumer protection globally. RA 7394 and DTI Policy Advisory No. 22-01 explicitly affirm this right in the Philippine context (DTI, 2022). Studies in rural provinces reveal, however, that many Filipino consumers lack awareness of their entitlement to price stability and quality standards (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023), leaving them vulnerable to exploitation. International literature also shows that vulnerable groups often experience barriers to accessing basic needs due to inconsistent regulatory enforcement (Mia & Mallick, 2021). Hence, awareness of this right is crucial for protecting consumer welfare.

The Right to Basic Needs ensures that consumers have access to essential goods and services at fair prices and acceptable quality, forming the foundation of consumer protection systems worldwide. The United Nations Guidelines for Consumer Protection emphasize that access to basic necessities is a fundamental consumer entitlement, particularly in developing economies where shortages and price instability are common (United Nations, 2022). In the Philippines, the Consumer Act (RA 7394) and DTI Policy Advisory No. 22-01 explicitly include this right as a priority, mandating government agencies to secure availability and affordability of essential goods (DTI, 2022). Studies examining provincial contexts show that Filipino consumers often experience uneven access to essential goods due to geographic and socioeconomic disparities. (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023) found that consumers in rural areas have lower awareness of their entitlement to basic needs protections, making them more vulnerable to overpricing and substandard products. Similarly, (Arellano-Asas, 2024) noted that while the legal framework supports this right, implementation remains variable across regions. International literature also highlights that inadequate enforcement of basic needs provisions can disproportionately affect vulnerable consumer groups, such as low-income households and seniors (Mia & Mallick, 2021). Overall, the Right to Basic Needs is essential because it protects consumers from exploitation and supports equitable access to essential goods.

Right to Safety

The Right to Safety requires that consumers be protected from hazardous products and services. In the Philippines, this right is legally anchored in RA 7394 and strengthened by the Food Safety Act (RA 10611), which mandates accurate labeling, safe processing, and removal of harmful products from the market (Republic Acts 7394 & 10611). International organizations such as the (OECD, 2023) emphasize that safety standards are essential in protecting consumers from harmful

goods, especially in markets with rapid product turnover. Studies in Manila reveal that despite legal protections, many consumers remain unaware of food safety provisions (Labana et al., 2024). Comparative Asian research indicates inconsistencies in safety enforcement (Dewi et al., 2024), highlighting the importance of safety awareness in consumer protection.

The Right to Safety guarantees consumers protection against hazardous products and services, requiring governments and businesses to uphold quality and safety standards. International frameworks similarly emphasize safety as a non-negotiable consumer entitlement; the (OECD, 2023) asserts that modern markets expose consumers to risks such as defective products, unsafe food items, and misleading claims, making safety a core priority of consumer policy. Local studies reinforce these concerns. (Labana et al., 2024) found that awareness of safety standards among Manila consumers was inconsistent, leading to risky consumption behaviors. (Dewi et al., 2024) also highlighted the varying quality of safety laws across Asian countries, including the Philippines, revealing inconsistencies in implementation and enforcement. These findings show that while the legal framework for consumer safety exists, awareness among consumers remains uneven, especially in rural or lower-income communities. Therefore, the Right to Safety remains critical to prevent harm and promote informed, health-conscious consumer behavior.

Right to Information

The Right to Information ensures that consumers are provided with accurate, truthful, and complete information necessary for making informed purchasing decisions. This includes proper labeling, transparent advertising, and disclosure of essential product characteristics. In the Philippines, RA 7394 mandates truthful product representation and prohibits misleading or deceptive advertising (Republic Act 7394). (Javier et al., 2024) demonstrated that consumers with

higher levels of education are more likely to read product labels, showing that Information Rights rely heavily on consumer engagement and literacy. (Baquiran et al., 2024) found that students with frequent exposure to consumer education had greater knowledge of misleading claims and label requirements. Internationally, the (ITU, 2024; OECD, 2023) warn that digital misinformation and deceptive online marketing have increased global risks, making the Right to Information even more vital.

Local studies in Cagayan and Quirino indicated that printed advisories and seminars helped improve awareness, but gaps persist in remote communities due to limited access to reliable information (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023). Protecting the Right to Information empowers consumers to evaluate product quality, avoid hazards, and make rational choices. Studies show that awareness of this right correlates strongly with education and media exposure. (Javier et al., 2024) found that Filipinos with higher education levels interpret labels more effectively, while (Baquiran et al., 2024) noted that students exposed to consumer education understand information rights better. Internationally, (ITU, 2024; OECD, 2023) warn that digital misinformation threatens information rights, necessitating stronger awareness programs. Provincial research also shows information gaps in rural areas (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023).

Right to Choose

The Right to Choose ensures that consumers have access to diverse and competitive product options. RA 7394 and the Philippine Competition Act (RA 10667) aim to protect consumers from anti-competitive behavior. Comparative studies in ASEAN regions reveal that strong competition laws lead to better product availability and quality (Galasintu & Loveera, 2021). (McKinsey, 2025) also reports that choice heavily influences consumer satisfaction. Locally,

awareness of this right is relatively low (Arellano-Asas, 2024), especially among rural consumers, indicating the need for broader education about competitive markets.

International comparisons highlight that countries with stronger competition and consumer protection laws offer consumers more choices and better product quality (Galasintu & Loveera, 2021). (McKinsey, 2025) global consumer studies also show that modern consumers value diverse product options and transparent pricing, which influences trust and satisfaction. Locally, (Arellano-Asas, 2024) noted that awareness of the Right to Choose remains low in Philippine provinces, limiting consumers' ability to identify unfair market practices. Demographic differences also influence consumers' ability to exercise this right, with more educated and younger consumers making more rational product comparisons (Lim, 2024; Nathiya & Kasthuri, 2021). Ensuring the Right to Choose protects consumers against market abuse and encourages healthy competition.

Right to Representation

The Right to Representation ensures that consumer voices are considered in policymaking. DTI Policy Advisory No. 22-01 identifies consumer participation as essential in shaping consumer welfare policies (DTI, 2022). However, local studies reveal limited awareness of representation channels such as consumer councils or ConsumerNet (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023). International studies indicate that strong representation improves transparency and regulatory responsiveness (Koos, 2021). Strengthening this right empowers consumers to influence market fairness. (Koos, 2021) highlights that strong representation structures help ensure that consumer interests balance business influence, leading to more equitable regulations.

Philippine institutional mechanisms, such as ConsumerNet and Local Price Coordinating Councils, aim to operationalize this right by facilitating communication between consumers and

regulatory bodies (DTI, 2023). However, local studies show participation remains weak. Surveys in Cagayan and Quirino found that many consumers were unaware of existing representation channels, reducing their ability to influence policy or report systemic violations (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023). International research also indicates that when representation is low, complaint resolution declines and consumer trust weaken (Koos, 2021). Strengthening representation is therefore essential for empowering communities and improving accountability in enforcement.

Right to Redress

The Right to Redress ensures that consumers can seek compensation or remedies for defective, unfairly priced, or falsely advertised products. According to RA 7394, consumers have the right to refunds, replacements, and repairs, with DTI empowered to enforce these provisions (Republic Act 7394). Regional studies in Quirino and Cagayan show low complaint filing due to lack of awareness, institutional access, or trust in enforcement (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023). International evidence indicates similar challenges in other developing countries (Agbo-Ejeh, 2023). Awareness of redress mechanisms is therefore critical for consumer empowerment.

Studies by (Arellano-Asas, 2024) show that while the legal framework for redress exists, many Filipinos are unaware of complaint procedures or lack confidence in the system. Local-level assessments in Quirino and Cagayan also revealed low complaint filing rates despite violations being common, largely due to limited awareness and weak institutional access (Melad et al., 2023; Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023). International studies support these findings, lack of trust in institutions and perceived inefficiency often prevent consumers from exercising their redress rights (Agbo-Ejeh, 2023). Awareness campaigns and institutional support are therefore vital to help consumers understand and assert their redress rights, especially in regions far from DTI offices.

Right to Consumer Education

The Right to Consumer Education ensures that individuals receive the knowledge necessary to make informed choices. (DTI, 2022) mandates educational programs to strengthen awareness. (Selvi and Anusuya, 2021) argue that consumer education promotes the ability to detect deceptive practices and understand product information. Philippine studies show that school- and community-based programs significantly improve awareness levels (Baquiran et al., 2024). (OECD, 2023) also emphasizes the need for digital consumer education due to rising online fraud risks.

However, local surveys reveal uneven access to education programs (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023; Melad et al., 2023), underscoring the need for inclusive educational efforts. Philippine research supports this: (Baquiran et al., 2024) found that consumers exposed to school-based and community education programs showed significantly higher awareness of the Eight Basic Consumer Rights. Similarly, (OECD, 2023) emphasizes that as markets become digitalized, consumer education must expand to cover online fraud, data protection, and misleading digital advertising.

Right to a Healthy Environment

The Right to a Healthy Environment protects consumers from environmentally harmful goods and practices. RA 7394 connects consumer welfare with environmental protection, while (DTI, 2022) stresses the importance of sustainability. International studies show rising consumer interest in eco-friendly products, but also highlight the need for transparency in environmental claims (Mbokane et al., 2024). (McKinsey, 2025) reports that environmental consciousness is shaping modern purchasing decisions. In the Philippine context, environmental regulations such

as RA 9003 (Ecological Solid Waste Management Act) complement consumer protection by mandating environmentally safe packaging and disposal.

Local surveys show that despite increasing interest in environmental issues, awareness of environmental consumer rights remains limited, especially in rural areas (Arellano-Asas, 2024). However, awareness of this right remains limited across Philippine provinces (Arellano-Asas, 2024), requiring stronger educational and institutional initiatives. (McKinsey, 2025) global consumer trends report notes that consumers increasingly prefer eco-friendly products but require clearer labeling and institutional support to make sustainable choices. Strengthening this right is essential because environmental risks—such as pollution and toxic products—directly affect consumer health and long-term well-being.

Age

Age is widely recognized as a major determinant of consumer awareness and legal literacy, influencing how individuals process product information, perceive risks, and engage in consumer protection behaviors. Younger consumers tend to be more exposed to digital platforms and online campaigns, giving them greater access to updated consumer information and safety advisories (Nathiya & Kasthuri, 2021). In contrast, older consumers often rely on traditional media, community discussions, and experience-based judgment, which may limit their exposure to current consumer regulations and digital complaint mechanisms (Kainyu, 2023). Philippine studies likewise confirm that age significantly predicts product label reading and comprehension, with younger groups showing more consistent engagement in evaluating product information (Javier et al., 2024). Because awareness of consumer rights—such as the Right to Safety and Right to Information—requires timely and accurate information processing, age becomes a meaningful variable in understanding disparities in consumer protection knowledge across local communities.

Evidence from regional surveys in the Philippines also reveals that older age groups, especially in rural areas, tend to have lower awareness of the Eight Basic Consumer Rights and lower likelihood of filing complaints (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023).

Age can strongly influence on how aware they are of their rights as a consumer and how confident they feel about standing up for them. (Rawal, 2021) established that college students are becoming aware of consumer issues but lack depth in understanding legal remedies. (Kainyu, 2023) noted that older consumers in Nairobi show experiential knowledge but lack formal legal awareness. (Nathiya and Kasthuri, 2021) indicated that middle-aged consumers in Tamil Nadu have balanced awareness due to economic and family decision-making roles. In the Philippines, (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023) found that younger respondents in Cagayan were aware of product safety but unfamiliar with legal complaint mechanisms. (Valvi et al., 2025) also observed that younger buyers of Sugam Ice Cream in Vadodara show brand awareness but not legal protection awareness, illustrating how age influences purchasing focus. Therefore, age must be included as a demographic factor, as it influences consumers' awareness levels, information-seeking behavior, and engagement with redress systems.

Educational Attainment

Education is also considered one of the determining variables in consumer literacy. (Baquiran et al., 2024) reported that ISU–Cauayan City Campus students have a moderate level of awareness of RA 7394 but often fail to understand its implementation mechanisms. (Devi and Kalita, 2020) indicated that restricted educational opportunities among rural women in Assam contribute to poor awareness of consumer rights. Similarly, (Mohammed Ashraf and Franklin, 2025) also discovered that education is one of the significant predictors of consumer participation in the Malappuram District. Against this background, (Selvi and Anusuya, 2021) conducted a

critical review of consumer rights education and concluded that classroom-based consumer education develops both awareness and confidence in exerting their legal rights. (Alonzo and Caurel, 2023) also found that educated consumers in Northern Philippines were more likely to question unfair practices. These studies suggest that strengthening educational interventions, particularly within secondary and tertiary institutions, will go a long way toward improving consumer protection literacy.

Educational attainment consistently emerges as one of the strongest predictors of consumer awareness, comprehension of product information, and understanding of legal remedies. (Osei, 2024) regional review demonstrated that education enhances consumers' ability to interpret labels, understand safety warnings, and identify misleading advertisements. In the Philippines, (Javier et al., 2024) confirmed that individuals with higher education levels are more capable of reading and evaluating product labels—a behavior linked to the Right to Information and Right to Safety. (Pajarillo- Agustin, 2023) found similar patterns in Cagayan, where consumers with lower education levels were less aware of their rights under RA 7394 and less likely to engage in redress processes. Education equips individuals with critical thinking skills needed to assess product quality, verify claims, and navigate formal complaint mechanisms. Since the Eight Basic Consumer Rights require not only awareness but also comprehension and application, educational attainment plays a direct role in enabling consumers to protect themselves effectively. Thus, its inclusion as a demographic factor is highly justified.

Gender

Gender can shape how people understand and act on their consumer rights, but its impact often depends on the social and cultural context. According to (Tshiki, 2025), women in low-income areas of Durban, South Africa, are less conscious of consumer rights because of economic

marginalization. Similarly, (Devi and Kalita, 2020) notice that women in Assam are usually the main decision-makers, but they lack awareness about complaint procedures. (Nathiya and Kasthuri, 2021) concluded that educated women tend to be more cautious and rights-conscious buyers than men. (Melad et al., 2023) showed minimal gender differences among consumers in Quirino, Philippines, which they explained shows increased equality in awareness, while (Man Mohan et al., 2025), in their study in Shimla, reported the increased interest among women regarding knowledge of the Consumer Protection Act after being exposed to advocacy campaigns. The above findings basically indicate that though gender differences are present throughout the world, education and outreach programs are bringing such gaps closer together bit by bit.

Gender differences also shape consumer awareness and engagement in consumer protection activities. Studies indicate that women tend to be more attentive to product safety, nutritional labels, and consumer advisories, especially regarding household goods and food items (Nathiya & Kasthuri, 2021). Women also appear more proactive in seeking product information and verifying labeling accuracy, likely due to their active role in household purchasing decisions. (Kainyu, 2023) found that female consumers in community settings exhibited higher awareness of consumer rights and consumer protection laws than males, who were less likely to read product labels thoroughly or participate in institutional complaint processes. In the Philippines, research has similarly shown that gender differences affect consumer literacy: females tended to read and understand labels more frequently and express stronger interest in safety-related information (Javier et al., 2024). These differences highlight the need to analyze gender as a demographic variable, as it influences the depth of consumer awareness, the vigilance toward safety standards, and the likelihood of engaging with consumer education initiatives.

Customer Category (PWD, Senior, Able-Bodied)

Customer category, particularly the classification of consumers into able-bodied individuals, seniors, or persons with disabilities (PWDs), significantly influences consumer rights awareness and access to information. Vulnerable groups such as seniors and PWDs often face barriers related to mobility, accessibility, and information availability, limiting their participation in consumer education campaigns (Kainyu, 2023). International studies show that vulnerable populations have lower exposure to consumer protection messaging and are less able to navigate digital platforms where most advisories are posted (Osei, 2024). In the Philippine context, regional surveys (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023) show that seniors and rural consumers have less familiarity with consumer rights and complaint procedures due to physical limitations and limited access to formal institutions like DTI offices. (Nathiya and Kasthuri, 2021) also noted that consumers belonging to socio-economically vulnerable groups often rely on informal networks for information, which increases the risk of misinformation and safety violations. Since PWDs and seniors are recognized as priority groups in government programs, examining their consumer rights awareness helps determine whether legal protections and information systems are accessible and equitable.

Customer category affects consumers' access to information and understanding of their rights. Seniors and persons with disabilities (PWDs) are often at greater risk due to physical limitations, difficulty accessing digital platforms, and reduced engagement in consumer education activities. Studies show that vulnerable groups tend to rely on informal sources of information that may be incomplete or inaccurate (Nathiya & Kasthuri, 2021). International research further highlights that PWDs and the elderly have lower levels of consumer rights awareness due to barriers in accessibility and information exposure (Osei, 2024; Kainyu, 2023). Philippine surveys also reveal that seniors and rural consumers report less knowledge about consumer rights and

complaint procedures (Pajarillo-Agustin, 2023). Understanding customer categories helps assess how equitably consumer rights are upheld across different population segments.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored on the *Consumer Empowerment Theory* and the *Information Integration Theory*, which explain how awareness and access to information influence consumer decision-making.

Consumer Empowerment Theory (CET)

Consumer Empowerment Theory posits that consumers become capable of making informed decisions when they have access to adequate information, the ability to understand their rights, and opportunities to exercise them. According to CET, empowered consumers can assess product quality, identify unfair practices, and demand appropriate redress when necessary. Awareness and knowledge of consumer rights, such as those articulated in RA 7394 are essential dimensions of empowerment. In this study, CET supports the idea that consumers with greater knowledge of the Eight Basic Consumer Rights are more empowered to protect themselves and respond to unfair or unsafe business practices.

Information Integration Theory (IIT)

Information Integration Theory explains how individuals acquire, process, and interpret information to form judgments or decisions. IIT highlights that the extent to which people integrate new information depends on two factors: Availability of information and Exposure to communication channels. In this study, IIT supports the additional independent variable—access to consumer information—because consumers who frequently encounter information from media, institutions, or DTI campaigns are more likely to be aware of their rights and apply them in real-life situations.

Through these theories, the study establishes a foundation for understanding the link between demographic profile, access to consumer information, and awareness of basic consumer rights.

1.4 Schematic Diagram

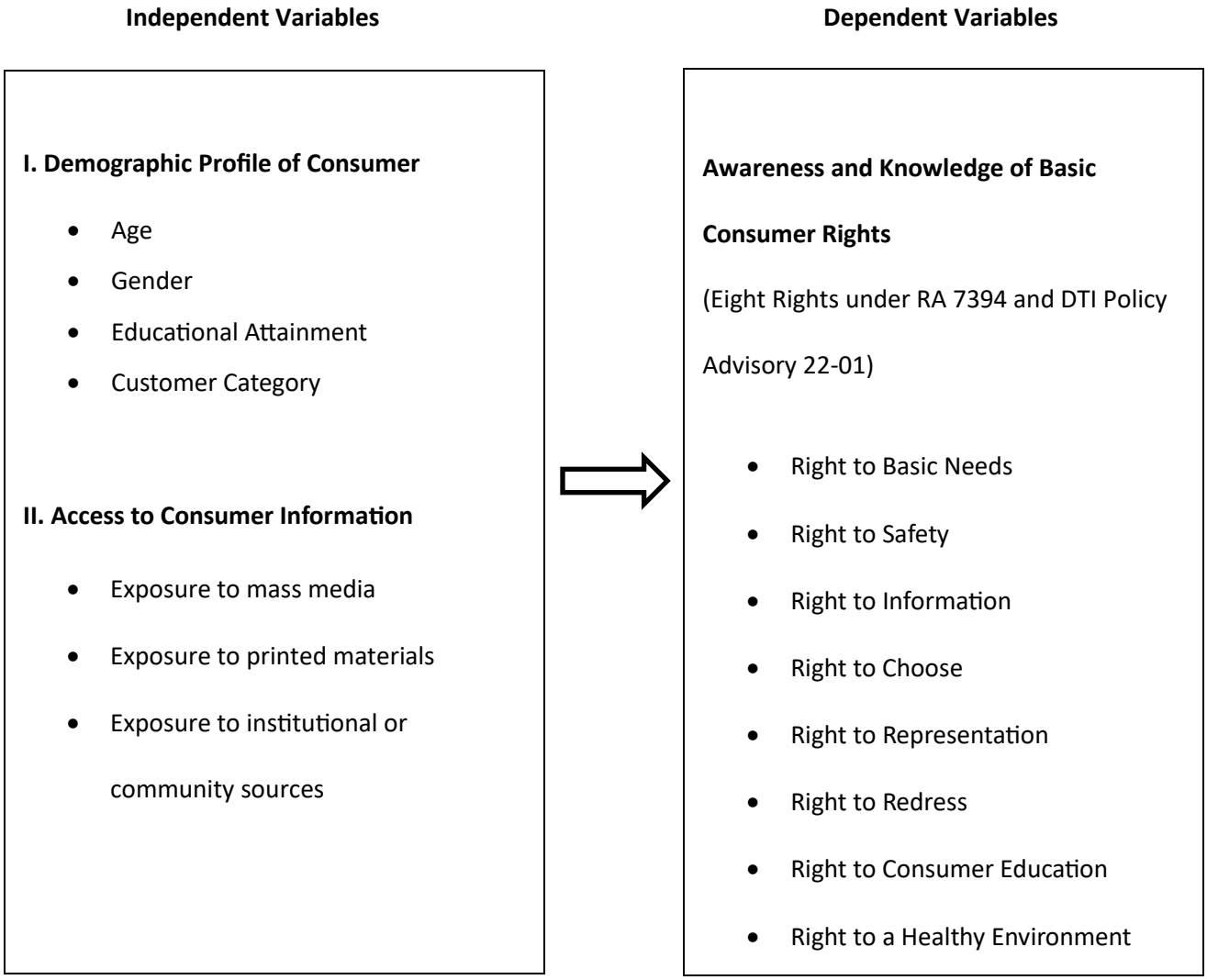


Figure 1. The Schematic Diagram shows the interplay between the independent and dependent variables of the study.

1.5 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study

This study aims to assess the awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights as mandated under Republic Act 7394 and reinforced by DTI Policy Advisory No. 22-01. Specifically, it seeks to answer the following questions:

1. What is the demographic profile of the respondents in terms of:
    1.1 Age;
    1.2 Gender;
    1.3 Educational Attainment; and
    1.4 Customer Category?
2. What is the level of access to consumer information of the respondents in terms of:
    2.1 Exposure to mass media;
    2.2 Exposure to printed information materials; and
    2.3 Exposure to community or institutional information sources?
3. What is the level of awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights in terms of:
    3.1 Right to Basic Needs;
    3.2 Right to Safety;
    3.3 Right to Information;
    3.4 Right to Choose;
    3.5 Right to Representation;
    3.6 Right to Redress;
    3.7 Right to Consumer Education; and
    3.8 Right to a Healthy Environment?

4. Is there a significant relationship between the demographic profile of respondents and their level of awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights?

5. Is there a significant relationship between access to consumer information and the level of awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights?

Hypothesis

Null Hypothesis

H_{01}: There is no significant relationship between the demographic profile of respondents and their level of awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights.

H_{02}: There is no significant relationship between the access to consumer information and the level of awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights.

1.6 Scope and Limitations

This study focuses on three municipalities of Agusan del Norte, located in the Caraga Region of Mindanao, Philippines. The study includes chosen municipalities: Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, both urban and rural communities. The study population are adult consumers, aged 18 years old and above, who live in Agusan del Norte and have been involved in purchasing goods and services from retail stores, such as supermarket, grocery stores, and convenience stores. Respondents are identified through simple random sampling, wherein respondents are deliberately chosen based on specific characteristics relevant to the study. These characteristics include geographical location, age, gender, and educational attainment, to ensure that participants possess the knowledge or experience necessary to provide meaningful insights into the study's topic.

1.7 Definition of Terms

The terms are operationally defined based on their use in this study.

8 Basic Consumer Rights. Refers to the respondents' awareness and understanding of the eight fundamental consumer rights as measured by their answers to survey items in the study.

Age. Used to categorize consumers into generational groups to determine whether awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights vary across age brackets.

Consumers. Refers to any individual residing in Agusan del Norte who purchases or receives goods or services from any business establishment, whose awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights are assessed.

Consumer Awareness. Defined as the extent to which consumers in Agusan del Norte are informed about their basic consumer rights and responsibilities, as measured through the data-gathering tools used in this study.

Consumer Rights. Refers to the specific entitlements guaranteed to consumers under RA 7394, including the right to safety, information, choice, and redress as understood and exercised by respondents in Agusan del Norte.

Educational Attainment. Refers to the level of formal education completed by the respondent, which is used to analyze whether consumer awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights are influenced by educational background.

Exposure to Mass Media. This refers to the extent to which respondents access information through mass communication channels such as television, radio, and online news platforms. In this study, it is measured by the respondents' self-reported frequency and duration of using these media sources.

Exposure to Printed Materials. This refers to the degree to which respondents engage with printed informational resources, including newspapers, magazines, brochures, flyers, or books. In this study, it is measured by how often and how long respondents read or use such materials.

Exposure to Institutional or Community Sources. This refers to the level of contact respondents have with information disseminated through formal institutions and community organizations, such as schools, health centers, government offices, religious groups, or local community programs.

Gender. Refers to the biological classification of respondents, used to explore potential differences in consumer awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights between sexes.

RA 7394 (Consumer Act of the Philippines). The term RA 7394 also known as the Consumer Act of the Philippines is defined as the primary legal framework assessed in this study, focusing on its enforcement in Agusan del Norte.

Right to Basic Needs. Refers to level to which consumers in Agusan del Norte can obtain basic goods and services at fair prices and satisfactory quality, measured by their knowledge and perception of access to such necessities.

Right to Safety. It relates to consumer's level of awareness of their protection from unsafe or defective products, and their confidence that businesses and government agencies enforce safety standards under RA 7394.

Right to Information. Define as a respondents' awareness of their right to honest and complete information about goods and services, such as clear labeling, advertising, and product content.

Right to Choose. The right to choose from variety of products and services at competitive prices.

Right to Representation. The right for consumer interests to be heard and represented in the making of government policies.

Right to Redress. The right to be compensated for mis presentation, poor quality goods, or unsatisfactory services.

Right to Consumer Education. The right to acquire to knowledge and skills needed to be informed consumer

Right to a Healthy Environment. The right to live and work in an environment that is safe and allows for formal life.

CHAPTER 2

METHODOLOGY

2.1 Research Design

This study employs a descriptive-quantitative research design to examine consumer awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights in Agusan del Norte. This method focuses on gathering numerical data through a structured questionnaire to measure consumers' level of awareness and their understanding of fundamental consumer rights. Using statistical tools, the study aims to identify relationships between key variables such as age, gender, education level, and the respondents' awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights. This approach allows for an objective analysis of the current situation without altering existing conditions, providing a clear and measurable understanding of consumer rights awareness in the study area.

2.2 Research Locale

This study is conducted in Agusan del Norte, a province located in the Caraga Region in Mindanao, Philippines. The study focuses on three municipalities: Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. These areas were carefully selected because of their distinct economic characteristics within the province. Buenavista, as a developing trade and service center with expanding commercial activity, is considered a strategic area for assessing the level of awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights.

Meanwhile, Nasipit, known for its port and vibrant commercial operations, serves as the province's main gateway of commerce. This setting presents unique opportunities and challenges in understanding how consumers and businesses engage with basic consumer rights. Carmen, on the other hand, is known for its agriculture and natural resource–based businesses, making it an important area for examining consumer rights awareness in both rural and semi-urban contexts.

2.3 Research Respondents

The respondents of the study are registered consumers residing in Agusan del Norte, Philippines, who are eighteen (18) years old and above. They represent various segments of the population, including individuals from both rural and urban areas who engage in consumption activities through traditional markets. As adults, these consumers are capable of making independent purchasing decisions. They also serve as the primary group whose awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights are being assessed in this study.

Table 1. Population and Sample Size

RESPONDENTS	POPULATION			SAMPLE SIZE					
	Male	Female	Total	Male		Female		Total	
				f	%	f	%	f	%
Buenavista	31,745	30,602	62,347	110	28.6	106	27.6	216	56.3
Nasipit	14,843	15,275	30,118	51	13.3	53	13.8	104	27.1
Carmen	9,197	9,111	18,308	32	8.3	32	8.3	64	16.7
Total	55,785	54,988	110,773	193	50.3	191	49.7	384	100.0

2.4 Research Instrument

The study will utilize a structured survey questionnaire as its main tool for data collection, which is modified from the instrument developed by Chona Pajarillo-Agustin in her study *"Consumer Awareness Assessment Survey in the province of Cagayan."*

While the original instrument provided the foundation, the questionnaire was partially modified and contextualized to suit the present study's objectives and research locale. These adjustments ensured that the instrument would accurately capture information on consumer awareness, knowledge on basic consumer rights under RA 7394 also known as The Consumer Act of the Philippines and DTI Policy Advisory 22-01.

The survey instrument is divided into three (3) parts:

Part I – Demographic Profile of the Respondents: This section gathers basic information such as age, gender, educational attainment, and customer category.

Part II – Access to Consumer Information: This section assesses respondents' level of access to consumer information such as exposure to mass media, exposure to printed information materials, and exposure to community or institutional information services.

Part III – Awareness and Knowledge of Basic Consumer Rights: This section has two sections; Awareness Subsection: Respondents rate their level of awareness of each right.
Knowledge Subsection (Function-Based): Respondents indicate their level of agreement with statements reflecting the practical application of each right.

The data collected from these sections served as a comprehensive basis for analyzing the extent of consumer awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights, as well as for generating insights relevant to understanding the level of consumer protection in Agusan del Norte.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Intellectual Property Rights (IPR)

This study will not cover the creation of any innovative technology or product that requires patent protection. An existing research instrument will be used as a basis for modifying or adapting the survey questionnaire that will be used in this study. Permission will be required from the original creator of this instrument. Copyright laws will be used to ensure that the updated instrument is protected and appropriate in the particular situation. Since no new logo or symbol is being created, trademark registration is also not required.

B. Informed Consent

The researcher will inform the people who are taking part in the study what it is for and how it will help them through a formal orientation and a written consent form. Participants will be asked to sign the permission form to show that they agree. Participants will have the chance to ask questions and the option to decline or leave at any moment. The study will not include trials on animals or living organisms, hence, ethical permission for such operations will not be obtained.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The researcher will keep all of the answers completely private and only use them for research. To safeguard the privacy of participants, all the information collected will be made anonymous. The data will be safely stored in a password-protected file that only the researcher and academic supervisors can access. Explicit written consent will be acquired from the respondents in case it is shared with third parties. All procedures will be fulfilled with ethical standards for research involving human participants.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw

The participation in this study will be at the participants' free will. Every respondent will be informed of the purpose and procedures of the analysis, together with their rights to withdraw without suffering any consequences.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

The study will be executed meticulously to prevent any physical, psychological, or emotional risk to the individuals involved. There will be no sensitive information in the survey questionnaire. People who answer the survey will be fully informed about the study's goals, the measures that will be taken, and the risks involved. Participants will be notified of their rights to withdraw at any time without implications if they experience discomfort. If participants are distressed, there will be a support service available to help them. This way, they can get help if they need it. The research will not involve animal participants, therefore, animal welfare and the 3Rs (Replacement, Reduction, Refinement) were not applicable.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

This study will have a positive impact on both the academic community and society as a whole since it will provide data-driven insights concerning consumer awareness and protection in Agusan del Norte. This conforms with the implementation of Republic Act 7394, also known as the Consumer Act of the Philippines. The results of this study will be a valuable resource for local governments, helping them make better policies, promote future academic research, and help groups who want to increase consumer welfare. Participants will be able to get the research results if they ask for them.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

This study will select volunteers fairly and transparently. Those who live in Agusan del Norte and are registered will be able to join. The selection process will ensure that individuals

from the specified demographic in the study are included in a just and equitable manner. It is essential to treat all groups equally to make the study more reliable and fairer.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Standardized approaches will be used to ensure that both data collection and analysis are accurate and trustworthy. The survey tool will be modified based on validated sources to provide clarity and alignment with the study objectives. To make comparisons easier and reduce differences, all participating consumers will use the same methods to collect data. We will use appropriate statistical techniques to conduct quantitative analysis so that it is fair and accurate. A statistician will help the researchers ensure the data analysis is correct. To keep things honest and open, any potential biases, mistakes, or restrictions will be carefully examined and acknowledged.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting

The study's results will be reported honestly and openly, making sure that all interpretations of the data are based on data that was collected honestly and carefully and has not been made up or changed. All copyrighted and patented materials utilized in the research and development will be appropriately credited and recognized in compliance with ethical and academic norms.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

This study won't use any proprietary technologies, so it won't need permission from patent holders. The research will utilize copyrighted materials, encompassing published literature and survey instruments sourced from reputable academic and governmental publications. All content will be appropriately attributed and credited in accordance with intellectual property rights laws. When necessary, the proper permits will be sought to make sure that ethical standards are followed and that the original authorship is respected.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

All human participants will be fully informed of the potential risks and benefits before their involvement. A written informed consent form will be provided. Participants will be made aware of their right to withdraw at any time without penalty. This study will not involve the use of animals; therefore, ethical clearance for animal trials will not be applicable.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Other Related Technologies

The study will use AI to help with several parts of the research process. The project will employ ChatGPT and Microsoft Pilot to aid the researcher in writing, alongside Grammarly and Quillbot to improve grammatical precision. These AI techniques will help the paper by making it more efficient and helping to find patterns and trends in quantitative data. To protect the integrity of both the data and the use of AI, the researcher will carefully check and confirm that all AI-generated outputs are correct and valuable. We will be open about any work that AI makes, and we will observe strong ethical standards for data protection, authorship, and intellectual property throughout the investigation.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval

Ethical approval for this study will be obtained from the institutional review board of Saint Michael College of Caraga. The committee will review the research proposal to ensure that all procedures involving human participants comply with ethical standards.

N. Disposal of Instrument

All research instruments and collected data will be handled responsibly throughout and after the study. Hard copies of the accomplished survey questionnaires will be stored securely in a locked storage box within the research office or designated faculty room. These documents will be kept for five (5) years in compliance with institutional and ethical research standards. After the

retention period, all hard copies will be securely shredded to ensure the complete protection of participant information.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure

With the permission of the appropriate authorities, the researchers will visit the Commission on Elections (COMELEC), the Local Government Unit, and the Barangay offices in the selected municipalities: Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. The purpose of these visits is to collect essential documents and population data from the selected areas, which will serve as supporting references for the study.

Once permission is secured, the researchers will personally distribute the survey questionnaires to the selected consumers. Respondents will be given sufficient time to answer the questions honestly. After completion, the questionnaires will be retrieved for analysis. The responses will then be organized, analyzed, and interpreted using statistical tools to summarize the findings on consumer awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights in Agusan del Norte.

Letter of Approval

A formal letter of request will be submitted to the local government, the Commission on Elections, and the Barangay offices to request validation and permission to conduct the study.

Orientation

An orientation meeting will be conducted to explain the purpose of the study and the ethical standards. This ensures that the participants understand their role and the importance of their responses.

Distribution of Informed Consent Form

Participants will receive informed consent forms to confirm they understand their rights and willingly agree to participate in the study. They will be informed that they can leave at any time without consequences.

Distribution of Questionnaires

The researchers will personally give the survey questionnaires to the chosen respondents. Enough time will be provided so they can answer the questions carefully and honestly without any distractions. This process helps ensure that the answers collected are accurate, reliable, and truly show the respondents' opinions.

Retrieval of Questionnaires and Consent Form

After the given time, the researchers will collect the completed questionnaires and consent forms for data analysis.

Gathering and Analysis of Data

All the collected data will be reviewed for completeness, organized, and analyzed using appropriate statistical methods. The descriptive-quantitative method will be used to analyze the results and draw conclusions on consumers' awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights.

2.7 Data Analysis Plan and Procedure

This study utilizes a quantitative research approach to determine the level of consumer awareness and knowledge of basic consumer rights in the province of Agusan del Norte. Primary data are collected through structured survey questionnaires administered to a representative sample of consumers randomly selected from the chosen municipalities in the province. The survey measures consumers' awareness of their basic rights, their experiences in exercising these rights, and their overall level of knowledge regarding consumer protection principles. To ensure that the sample reflects the heterogeneous population of Agusan del Norte, simple random

sampling is employed, and respondents are grouped according to key characteristics such as geographical location, age, gender, and income level.

The data are processed and analyzed using both descriptive and inferential statistical methods. Descriptive statistics such as frequency, percentage, mean, and standard deviation are used to summarize consumers' perceptions and levels of awareness of basic consumer rights. Inferential statistics, including chi-square and t-test, are used to determine significant relationships between key variables. All ethical considerations are strictly observed throughout the conduct of the study. Informed consent is obtained from all respondents prior to their participation. Confidentiality and anonymity are fully ensured, and all data gathered are used solely for academic purposes.

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APPENDICES

CERTIFICATE OF AUTHENTIC AUTHORSHIP